

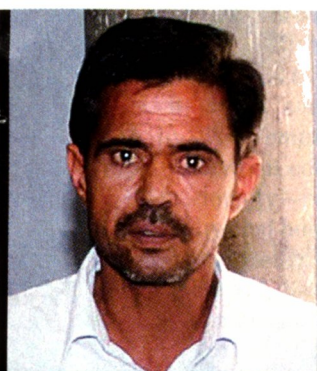
With the landmark judgement, now things may change. Ranbir Singh, a noted political scientist based in Karnal, says the judgement will embolden liberal sections of the society. "Since it's an exemplary punishment it will act as a deterrent. At the same time in the traditional set-up it won't be well received. They may not express it or come out on the roads to protest but there will be an undercurrent of resentment." The message has, however, been sent loud and clear: khap leaders who perhaps thought they were outside

court to depose, she was slapped by Suresh who was in police custody, alleges Khawal.

Manoj's family now plans to move the high court seeking capital punishment for Ganga Raj, the man allegedly behind the plot. Yet, the judgement is historical for many reasons. Honour killings take place on a routine basis in the state but this is the first time capital punishment has been awarded. Most of these killings have enjoyed the backing of the mighty kangaroo courts, which should have confined themselves to

sorting out minor village feuds but exceeded their jurisdiction. Over the past few years these panchayats have issued bizarre diktats to married couples such as to sever the marriage and accept each other as siblings, social boycott of their families and, if they still don't relent, provoking attacks on them which have claimed several young lives.

Even in this case, which had the stamp of the khap panchayat writ all over, it's the kidnappers and killers who have been sentenced, while the men behind it—read khap panchayat—who



RAJINDER, 41

Babli's uncle

SENTENCED TO DEATH



BARU RAM, 45

Babli's uncle

SENTENCED TO DEATH



MANDEEP SINGH, 27

SUV driver

SEVEN YEARS IN JAIL

76

hearings took place and 41 witnesses deposed in court before the verdict was pronounced.

the purview of the Indian Penal Code and could get away with any crime, have to abide by the law of the land. For the first time an honour killing has been taken to its logical conclusion in Haryana. "The deceased's souls will rest in peace today. We'd also sleep well tonight but we would have been happier if Ganga Raj too had got death sentence," says Narinder, who has defied the odds to fight the case.

The widowed mother Chanderpati (52), sister Seema (22), who is a Haryana police constable, and younger brother Vinod, who is a student, have chosen to keep a low profile and even on the day of sentencing they preferred to confine themselves to their village Karoran, about 60 km from Karnal. Actually, they have been forced to do so, after alleged repeated threats by the convicts' relations and the khap panchayat. When Seema appeared in the

Trial and Error

Some weird khap diktats in recent years

- In July 2009, Ved Pal Mor was lynched in Singhwal in front of the police after he married a girl from same gotra. Soon after, Ravinder and Shilpa were banished from a neighbouring village in Jhajjar.
- In May 2007, Nandgarh Barah panchayat ordered 12-year exile for a couple in a case of love marriage.
- In 2004, a khap panchayat of Ahulana village in Gohana declared Renu and Sunil Malik's marriage invalid although they had a child.

provoked them, go free. For young couples, the only hope lies in the judiciary. Politicians have always tended to look the other way since they cannot afford to annoy the powerful caste-based panchayats without seriously denting their votebanks. The police always have supported them as they enjoyed the political backing just as in this case. The media has been generally harsh on these self-styled keepers of public morality but they have mostly gone unrestrained. So it warranted a judicial intervention. In the past also courts have reprimanded the state Government for doing nothing, but to no avail.

The Karnal case will undoubtedly be contested in the higher courts by the convicts. But, a beginning has been made and hopefully, kangaroo courts that have terrorised young men and women over the years will be a thing of the past. ■